Average Cost of College by Year

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Report Highlights. The Education Data Initiative estimates tuition and fees* average **$18,981** for the 2025-26 academic year (AY); including room-and-board, the average is *$24,148*.

Public universities charge **$10,340** for AY25-26 resident tuition; private college tuition is *$39,307*.

The average cost of college tuition & fees rose **93.2%** between AY05-06 and AY25-26; adjusted for inflation, tuition increased *17.4%*.

In the last 60 years, the 1972-1973 academic year saw the largest year-over-year (YoY) college tuition growth at **17.5%**.

In the 21st Century, the cost of college has increased **41.7%** faster than the cost of inflation; the annual average tuition inflation rate is *3.91%* compared to a total inflation rate of *2.56%*.

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**The term "college" in this report refers to 4-year institutions unless otherwise noted.*

Jump to a decade: 1920s | 1930s | 1940s | 1950s | 1960s | 1970s | 1980s | 1990s | 2000s onward

Annual Cost of College Tuition & Fees

Year	Public	Private
2025-26	$10,340	$39,307
2024-25	$10,153	$37,937
2023-24	$9,961	$36,580
2022-23	$9,750	$35,248
2021-22	$9,596	$34,051
2020-21	$9,374	$32,728
2019-20	$9,349	$32,764
2018-19	$9,212	$31,883
2017-18	$9,036	$30,723
2016-17	$8,804	$29,476
2015-16	$8,778	$27,942
2014-15	$8,543	$26,739
2013-14	$8,312	$25,707
2012-13	$8,070	$24,523
2011-12	$7,713	$23,464
2010-11	$7,132	$22,677
2009-10	$6,717	$22,269
2008-09	$6,312	$22,040

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Year	Public	Private
2007-08	$5,943	$21,427
2006-07	$5,666	$20,517
2005-06	$5,351	$19,292
2004-05	$5,027	$18,604
2003-04	$4,587	$17,763
2002-03	$4,046	$16,826
2001-02	$3,735	$16,211
2000-01	$3,501	$15,470
1999-2000	$3,349	$14,616
1998-99	$3,229	$13,973
1997-98	$3,110	$13,344
1996-97	$2,987	$12,881
1995-96	$2,848	$12,243
1994-95	$2,681	$11,481
1993-94	$2,537	$10,952
1992-93	$2,349	$10,294
1991-92	$2,117	$9,759
1990-91	$1,888	$9,083
1989-90	$1,780	$8,396
1988-89	$1,646	$7,722
1987-88	$1,537	$7,116
1986-87	$1,414	$6,658
1985-86	$1,318	$6,121

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Year	Public	Private
1984-85	$1,228	$5,556
1983-84	$1,148	$5,093
1982-83	$1,031	$4,639
1981-82	$909	$4,113
1980-81	$804	$3,617
1979-80	$738	$3,225
1978-79	$688	$2,958
1977-78	$655	$2,700
1976-77	$617	$2,534
1975-76	$542	$2,291
1974-75	$512	$2,130
1973-74	$514	$2,045
1972-73	$503	$1,948
1971-72	$428	$1,832
1970-71	$394	$1,706
1969-70	$358	$1,562
1968-69	$321	$1,417
1967-68	$310	$1,317
1966-67	$302	$1,241
1965-66	$278	$1,162
1964-65	$256	$1,097
1963-64	$243	$1,011

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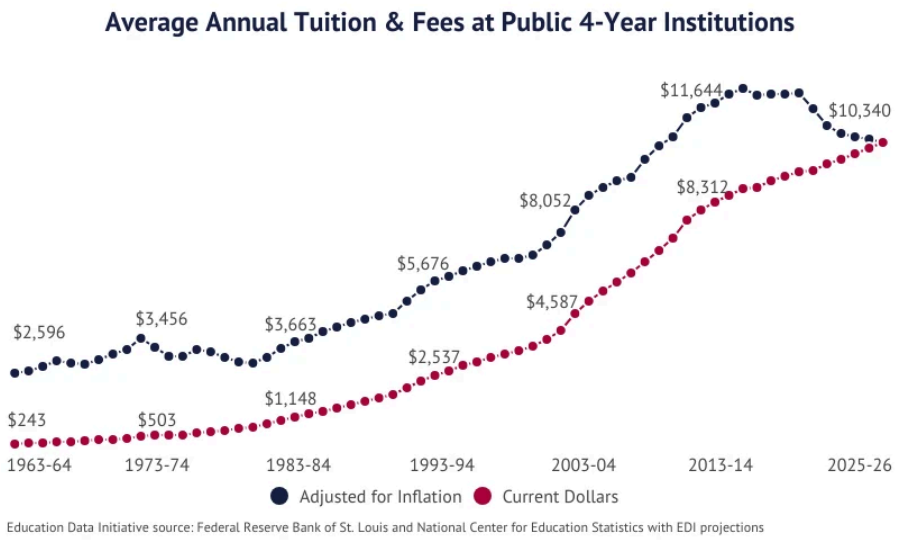
Related reports include: Average Student Loan Debt by Year | Student Loan Debt Crisis | Average Cost of Private School | Average Cost of Community College

Average Annual Tuition Growth

Tuition growth continues at a slower rate than it did between the mid-1970s and the 2000s.

> The average 4-year academic institution raised tuition rates 2.24% from AY24-25 to AY25-26.
>
> In the 21st century, the average college tuition has increased 157.5%; after adjusting for inflation, tuition has increased 37.5%.
>
> College student tuition and fees increased by an average 5.91% every year since AY1963-64.



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Public College Cost Statistics

Public 4-year academic institutions receive some funding from federal, state, and local tax dollars; public costs are for in-state students except where otherwise noted.

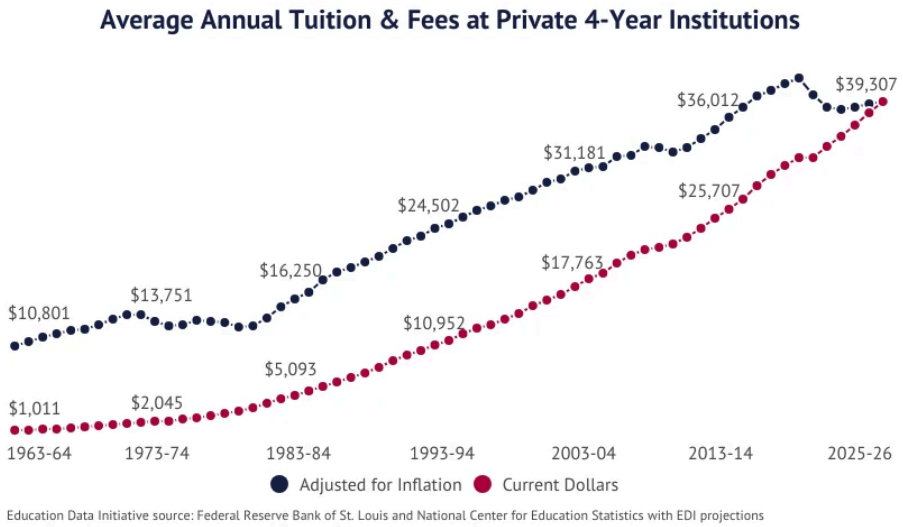
Since AY20-21, public universities have increased tuition for residents 10.3%.

Tuition for out-of-state students has increased 13.2% since AY20-21.

Compared to the average in-state tuition, out-of-state students pay almost three times as much ($30,672 compared to $10,340 for AY25-26).

In the 21st century, in-state tuition at the average public institution has increased 195%; after inflation, tuition has increased 57.7%.

From AY1963-64 until the end of the 20th century, annual tuition at the average public institution increased 970%; after inflation, tuition increased 148%.



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Private College Tuition Costs

Private institutions receive no institutional funding from federal or state governments.

Tuition at nonprofit universities has increased 17.0% since AY20-21; for-profit private institutions have increased tuition 7.66%.

In the 21st century, private nonprofit institutions have increased tuition 165%; after inflation, nonprofit tuition has increased 41.6%.

For-profit private colleges have increased tuition 59.2% in In the 21st century; after inflation, for-profit tuition has declined 15.0%.

Nonprofit private institutions charge an average of 86.7% more for tuition than private for-profit institutions.

Annual Cost of Private College Tuition & Fees

Year	Nonprofit	For-Profit
2025-26	$41,942	$16,579
2024-25	$40,765	$16,318
2023-24	$39,594	$16,081
2022-23	$38,421	$15,868
2021-22	$37,225	$15,505
2020-21	$35,852	$15,400
2019-20	$35,799	$14,957
2018-19	$34,770	$14,715
2017-18	$33,748	$14,677
2016-17	$32,717	$14,423

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Year	Nonprofit	For-Profit
2015-16	$31,578	$14,150
2014-15	$30,789	$13,924
2013-14	$29,823	$13,714
2012-13	$28,743	$13,691
2011-12	$27,616	$13,712
2010-11	$26,581	$13,727
2009-10	$25,535	$13,769
2008-09	$24,636	$14,423
2007-08	$23,328	$14,644
2006-07	$21,994	$14,593
2005-06	$20,732	$13,315
2004-05	$19,652	$13,197
2003-04	$18,584	$12,398
2002-03	$17,517	$11,407
2001-02	$16,604	$11,069
2000-01	$15,811	$10,411
1999-2000	$15,131	$8,661

Public vs. Private College Costs

Tuition at private colleges has increased faster than in-state public tuition.

> As of AY25-26, tuition and fees at the average private institution is nearly four times (4x) the cost of public

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institutions.

In 1947, tuition and fees for full-time undergraduates at the private nonprofit University of Pennsylvania‡ was $570 , the equivalent of $8,007 in 2024 dollars.

For AY25-26, U-Penn tuition and fees are $71,236, representing a 790% increase relative to 1947 after adjusting for inflation.

Ivy League University of Pennsylvania (U-Penn) raised annual undergraduate tuition and fees 3.75% for AY25-26.

In Fall 1947, the public University of North Carolina was $106 the equivalent of $1,489 in 2024 dollars.

For AY25-26, UNC tuition and mandatory fees are $4,543.50 representing a 205% increase from inflation-adjusted Fall 1947 tuition.

‡*Nationwide average tuition and fees prior to 1963 are unavailable; some institutions, however, keep public archives of their rate histories.*

Average Annual Cost of On-Campus Room & Board

Year	Public	Private
2025-26	$13,808	$15,819
2024-25	$13,418	$15,334
2023-24	$13,026	$14,864
2022-23	$12,639	$14,406
2021-22	$12,236	$13,879
2020-21	$11,963	$13,487

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Year	Public	Private
2019-20	$11,686	$13,161
2018-19	$11,386	$12,787
2017-18	$11,012	$12,408
2016-17	$10,684	$11,990
2015-16	$10,426	$11,592
2014-15	$10,089	$11,249
2013-14	$9,787	$10,892
2012-13	$9,404	$10,549
2011-12	$9,073	$10,213
2010-11	$8,788	$9,840
2009-10	$8,319	$9,577
2008-09	$7,900	$9,192
2007-08	$7,486	$8,800
2006-07	$7,133	$8,403
2005-06	$6,757	$8,041
2004-05	$6,399	$7,656
2003-04	$6,088	$7,306
2002-03	$5,741	$6,961
2001-02	$5,461	$6,685
2000-01	$5,153	$6,385
1999-2000	$4,925	$6,121
1998-99	$4,798	$5,956
1997-98	$4,564	$5,725

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1996-97	$4,347	$5,561
1995-96	$4,166	$5,368
1994-95	$3,990	$5,121
1993-94	$3,829	$4,951
1992-93	$3,670	$4,716
1991-92	$3,577	$4,498
1990-91	$3,355	$4,154
1989-90	$3,195	$3,906
1988-89	$3,032	$3,752
1987-88	$2,866	$3,543
1986-87	$2,724	$3,381
1985-86	$2,541	$3,108
1984-85	$2,454	$2,895
1983-84	$2,285	$2,666
1982-83	$2,164	$2,487
1981-82	$1,961	$2,217
1980-81	$1,805	$1,977
1979-80	$1,618	$1,788
1978-79	$1,457	$1,651
1977-78	$1,383	$1,540
1976-77	$1,319	$1,442
1975-76	$1,238	$1,378
1974-75	$1,134	$1,274

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Year	Public	Private
1973-74	$1,082	$1,177
1972-73	$1,051	$1,143
1971-72	$977	$1,087
1970-71	$932	$1,048
1969-70	$879	$982
1968-69	$822	$939
1967-68	$793	$909
1966-67	$764	$880
1965-66	$737	$852
1964-65	$710	$825
1963-64	$685	$799

Average Annual Cost of College

The cost of tuition and fees is just part of the total cost of college attendance, which also includes room and board, books and supplies, and various additional costs (such as transportation, event tickets, etc.).

The average cost of on-campus room and board is $14,409 for AY25-26.

On-campus student housing and meal plans average $8,200 and $6,211 respectively.

According to Zillow, the average 12-month rental costs $24,888 per year; an average two-bedroom rents for

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$22,200.

The USDA's Official Thrifty Food Plan suggests a monthly grocery budget between $247.70 and $317.20 depending on nutritional requirements†.

A frugal 2025 grocery budget for a college-aged consumer totals between $2,972 and $3,806.

† *For consumers aged 14 to 50 years old as of July 2025.*

Average Institutional College Costs

Federal and nonfederal support goes toward administrative costs as well as student financial aid.

Federal support for postsecondary education amounted to $174.9 billion in 2021; the 2022 budget of $577.5 billion included funding for the CARES Act.

An additional $83.6 billion comes from off-budget and non-federal support, most of which goes toward student financial aid.

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According to the Federal Reserve Bank, increased borrowing limits on student loans in recent years have had little to no meaningful effect on tuition rates in the long term.

Prior to 1993, the Federal Reserve estimates that tuition increased $0.10 for every $1 increase in borrowing limits.

Average Cost of College in the 21st Century

The latest data indicates that the escalation of academic costs may be slowing down, possibly below some YoY growth rates from the 1960s.

Between AY09-10 and AY25-26, the overall average cost of resident public tuition & fees saw an increase of 53.9%.

Also between AY09-10 and AY25-26, private 4-year schools (nonprofit and for-profit) increased costs 76.5%.

Between 1999-2000 and 2009-10, the cost of attendance at nonprofit private institutions grew from

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$20,989 per year to $34,920, an annual growth rate of 5.2%.

During the same period, for-profit private institutions increased the cost of attendance from $16,124 to $24,118, a 4.1% annual growth rate.

From 2009-10 to 2019-20, private nonprofits increased costs to $48,815.

In the same period, private for-profits increased costs to $27,561.

Between 1999-2000 and 2019-20, tuition at the average 4-year institution increased 136.5%.

Federal funding budgeted for postsecondary education totaled $23.0 billion in 2000.

In 2010, the budget increased to $58.2 billion, an annual growth rate of 9.73% from 2000.

In 2019, the budget was $107.5 billion, an annual growth rate of 7.06% from 2010.

In 2020 and 2021, the federal postsecondary budget was $213.5 billion and $236.8 billion respectively.

Federally mandated costs for postsecondary education increased 86.4% per year from 2010 to 2022; this growth rate is heavily inflated by funding for the CARES Act.

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Average Cost of College in the 20th Century

When the century began, many colleges were very low cost and some were free. After student financial aid became commonplace, college costs escalated beyond those of any other industry.

> In 1900, undergraduates paid $150 to attend the University of Pennsylvania and its Wharton School.
>
> By 1913, the annual cost to undergraduates increased to $160; this is a 0.50% average annual growth rate.
>
> In 1999, undergraduates paid $24,230 to attend U-Penn.
>
> After adjusting for inflation, the cost of a year as an undergraduate at U-Penn increased 803.3% between 1913 and 1999; this is a 2.6% average annual growth rate.
>
> Between the 1969-70 academic year to 1999-2000, the national average cost of tuition and fees at the average 4-year institution increased 832.5%.

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After adjusting for inflation, the annual growth rate of tuition between 1969-70 and 1999-2000 was 2.47%.

College Costs in the 1990s

The 1990s saw the rise of the for-profit college, which took advantage of federal funding programs. While such institutions charged less for attendance than their nonprofit counterparts, they would become notorious for hidden expenses, poor instruction, and fraud.

In the 1989-90 academic year, tuition at the average public 4-year institution was $1,780.

In 1999-2000, tuition at a public 4-year institution averaged $3,349; this is an average annual growth rate of 6.52%.

Between 1989-90 and 1999-2000, the total cost of attendance (fees, tuition, room, and board) increased 66.3% at public 4-year schools, from $4,975 to $8,274.

At private 4-year schools, the cost of tuition grew 74.1%, from $8,396 to $14,616.

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In that same period, the cost of attendance at a private 4-year institution increased from $12,284 to $20,737, an annual growth rate of 5.38%.

Tuition at the average public 2-year institution increased from $756 to $1,348, an annual growth rate of 5.95%.

Tuition at the average private 2-year institution increased 58.3%, from $5,196 to $8,225.

Among all postsecondary institutions, the cost of tuition increased at an average annual rate of 6.28%.

After adjusting dollar values for inflation, costs increased at an average annual rate of 3.30%.

The largest YoY average tuition increase was 8.95% between the 1990-91 and 1991-92 academic years.

After adjusting for inflation, the 1993-94 academic year saw a 6.07% increase in tuition over the previous year.

The federal budget for postsecondary education amounted to $18.1 billion in 1990.

Throughout the decade, the federal budget increased 27.3%.

If off-budget and nonfederal funds generated by federal legislation (most of which funded student loans) are included, total federal spending increased 86.1%.

Funding for FFEL loans increased by $11.9 billion or 110%.

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College Costs in the 1980s

Public investment in higher education dropped as college students and their families began borrowing at never before seen rates.

In the 1979-80 academic year, the average annual cost of tuition and fees at public 4-year institutions was $738.

By 1989-90, annual tuition and fees averaged $1,780, a 9.2% average annual growth rate.

Between 1979-80 and 1989-90, the total cost of attendance (#fees, tuition, room, and board) saw an increase of 113.8% at public 4-year schools, from $2,327 to $4,975.

At private 4-year schools, tuition grew 160.3%, from $3,225 to $8,396.

Between 1979-80 and 1989-90, the cost of attendance at private 4-year institutions grew from $5,013 per year to $12,284, an annual growth rate of 9.38%.

Tuition at the average public 2-year institution increased from $355 to $756, an annual growth rate of 7.85%.

Tuition at the average private 2-year institution increased 152.0%, from $2,062 to $5,196.

The federal budget for postsecondary education amounted to $11.1 billion in 1980.

Throughout the decade, the federal budget increased 62.9%.

If off-budget and nonfederal funds generated by federal legislation (#most of which funded student loans) are included, total federal spending increased 94.5%.

Funding for FFEL loans increased by $6.23 billion or 135.5%.

The most dramatic increase in costs to all postsecondary students was between the academic years of 1980-1981 and 1981-1982, when the average cost of attendance at any postsecondary institution grew 12.5%; that is:

> 33.4% faster than the rate of inflation at the time (which was 8.92%).
>
> 96.6% faster than the rate of academic inflation in the 21st century (4.36%).

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College Costs in the 1970s

A new national recession began, and federal student loans became commonplace. The average cost of tuition and fees at 4-year institutions doubled.

- Between 1969-70 and 1979-80, the cost of tuition and fees at the average public 4-year institution increased from $358 to $738, an average annual increase of 7.5%.
- The total cost of attendance (fees, tuition, room, and board) saw an increase of 88.0% at public 4-year schools, from $1,238 to $2,327.
- During that same period, tuition at private 4-year institutions grew from $1,562 to $3,225, an annual growth rate of 7.52%.
- The cost of attendance grew 95.9%, from $2,559 to $5,013.
- Tuition at the average public 2-year institution increased from $178 to $355, an annual growth rate of 7.15%.

Tuition at the average private 2-year institution increased 99.4%, from $1,034 to $2,062.

The federal budget for postsecondary education amounted to $3.4 billion in 1970.

Throughout the decade, the federal budget increased 223%.

If off-budget and nonfederal funds generated by federal legislation (most of which funded student loans) are included, total federal spending increased 210%.

Funding for FFEL loans increased by $3.83 billion or 497%.

College Costs in the 1960s

In 1965, the Higher Education Act was passed to help make college more affordable through financial aid from the government to students. Most federal data date to the 1963-64 academic year.

In the 1960s, the average cost of tuition and fees at any 4-year college increased at an annual rate of 5.33%.

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The average cost of attendance at any postsecondary institution grew at an annual rate of 4.06%.

In the 1963-64 academic year, tuition and fees at the average public 4-year university totaled $243 annually.

The cost of tuition and fees increased to $358 for 1969-70 at the average public 4-year university.

Between 1963-64 and 1969-70, the cost of tuition and fees at the average public 4-year institution increased 47.3%, growing at an annual rate of 6.67%.

During this same period, the total cost of attendance (#fees, tuition, room, and board) saw an increase of 33.3% at public 4-year schools.

Between 1963-64 and 1969-70, the cost of attendance at 4-year private institutions grew from $1,810 per year to $2,559, an annual growth rate of 5.94%.

During this same period, tuition at the average 2-year institution increased 44.4%, an annual rate of 6.32%.

Tuition at the average public 2-year institution increased from $97 to $178, an annual growth rate of 10.6%.

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College Costs in the 1950s

Official data from 1950 or earlier is, for the most part, unavailable. Some institutions, such as the University of Pennsylvania, maintain archives of such information.

In 1950, the U-Penn charged undergraduates $625 for the academic year.

In 1959, the annual cost totaled $1,400.

Throughout the decade, college costs rose 124% to the equivalent of $14,889 in January 2024 dollars.

Undergraduates attending U-Penn in the 2023-24 academic year will pay $66,104, a 337.3% increase over 1959 equivalent costs (that is, $15,115).

College Costs in the 1940s

Tuition was still relatively affordable for most households, and the first federal student aid program began.

In 1944, the Servicemen's Readjustment Act, also known as the GI Bill, provided federal aid for tuition, fees, and

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other educational expenses for veterans.

Veterans would receive a free year of college, up to $500 in tuition, and monthly living allowance while studying.

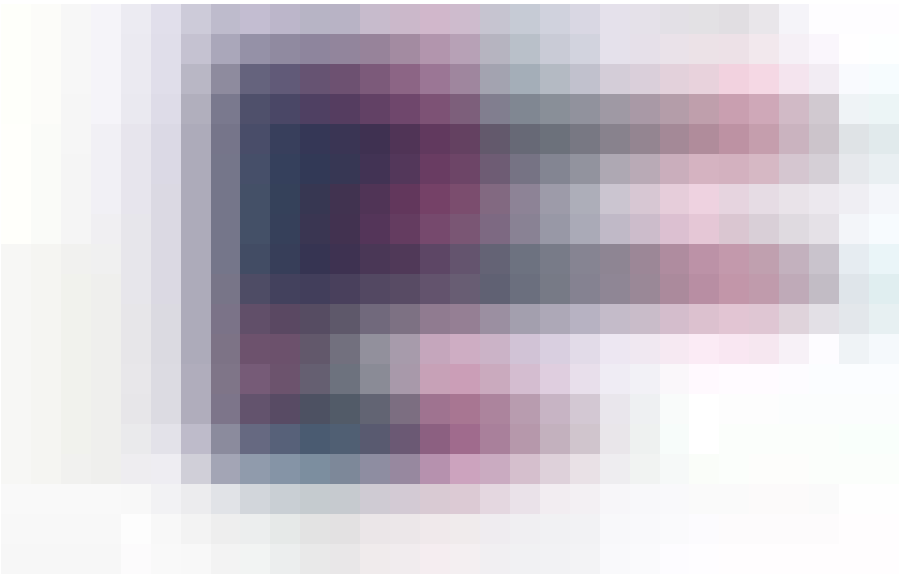
In 1947, veterans accounted for nearly half of college admissions.

Also in 1947, the cost to attend Harvard university was $525.

One year of Harvard attendance cost the equivalent of 17.5% of the average household income ($3,000).

Comparatively, attending Harvard for a year in 2011 cost $34,976, 69.9% of the nationwide median household income.

By 2014, the cost to attend Harvard was $38,891, equivalent to 72.5% of that year's median household income.



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College Costs in the 1930s

Through the height of the Great Depression, some postsecondary institutions kept costs low to account for

students' presumably reduced income.

In 1930, first-year undergraduates paid $400 to attend the University of Pennsylvania.

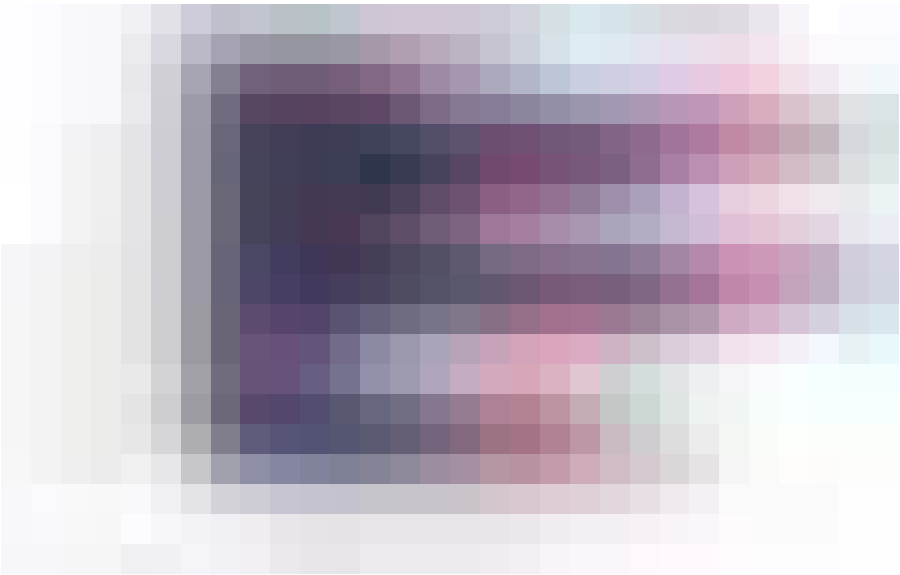
In 1939, the cost of attendance at the University of Pennsylvania increased to $420.

In 1934, the cost of attendance for first-year students at Dartmouth was $1,700 or $40,462 in January 2024 dollars.

Dartmouth lists $94,980 as their AY25-26 cost of attendance.

Dartmouth's tuition increased at an average rate of 4.52% per year over 90 years.

Adjusting for inflation, tuition values increase 0.90% per year.



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College Costs in the 1920s

Discharged World War I veterans packed postsecondary schools in the '20s. At the University of Washington,

enrollment grew from 3,000 in 1918 to 8,500 in 1931. There was no tuition assistance for veterans in this era.

In 1920, Stanford charged $120 per year ($1,953 in 2024 dollars).

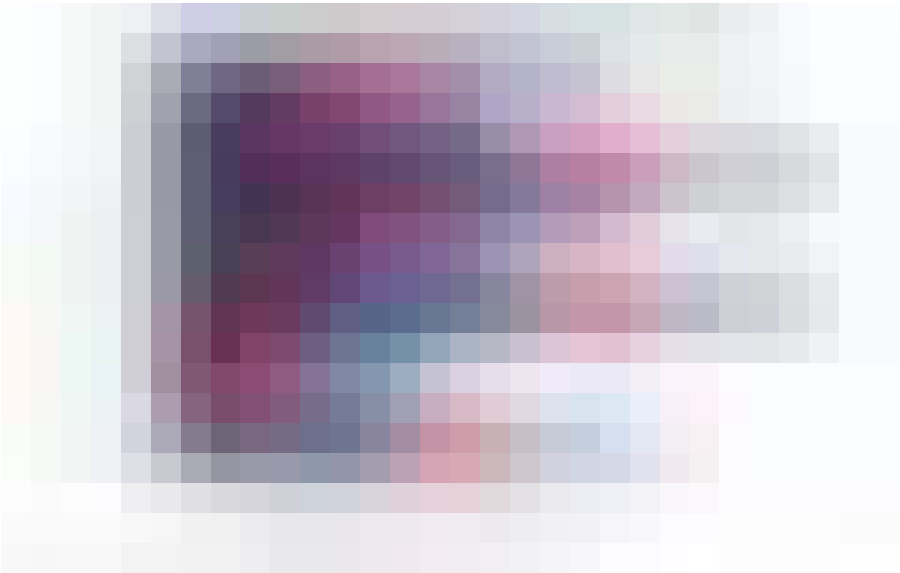
At the University of Pennsylvania, the annual cost of tuition and fees for a first-year undergraduate was $270.

In 1929, first-year students at U-Penn paid $400, a 48.1% increase.

For the average student, the year's textbooks totaled between $30 and $35.

Throughout the decade, the cost of room and board increased from $350 to $520.

Including all room and board costs, college freshmen in 1929 paid a total of $170 more than at the start of the decade, a 48.6% increase.



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We're a team of researchers who believe important discussions in education deserve to start from a place of fact, not opinion. From hot button topics like student loan debt to high school graduation rates, our mission is to make sure the data surrounding these topics is open & accessible.

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